FALLBACK ON TAWANG

THE GORKHAS AT TSANGDHAR

Brigadier Dalvi's lucid and gripping account of what transpired first between him and Lieutenant Colonel Rikh and then with the GOC of the division, Major General Niranjan Prasad, on the evening of 19 October has unfortunately acted as a smokescreen for his own failure to act decisively. While reiterating that the units were in a death trap, neither the brigade commander nor the GOC of 4 Division, despite being present on the ground, thought of pulling the Rajputs, the Punjabis and the Grenadiers back onto the Tsangdhar–Hathung-la axis, which would have been the most obvious thing to do. Even if Kaul's orders were to have been followed in both letter and spirit (of not abandoning the bridges), screen (covering) positions could have been left at the riverfront.

Despite having had nine days to redeploy his brigade which was strung out at the bottom of the valley, Dalvi was repeatedly denied permission by Prasad to redeploy further back on the Tsangdhar Ridge. The moment of truth was on 13 October when the orders to hold the existing positions were reiterated. Dalvi, at that point, as the commander on the ground, should have countermanded the order, something he had done before, and something that would have given the men trapped in the valley some semblance of a chance. He failed to do so. His dilemma is perhaps understandable, but in the ultimate analysis, inexcusable. He was to write later: 'I was alone and lonely at this crucial stage and, for the first time, felt the full impact of the loneliness of command… I should not have accepted the order to defend all the bridges over the Nam Ka Chu on the 13th of October, but then "It takes more courage to appear a coward than risk being killed".'

He goes on to say, 'If I left on tactical grounds, and the Chinese did not attack, I would be branded a physical coward. I did not have the moral courage to accept this stigma.' Dalvi says he asked Prasad if he had been